

be our biggest theme—just like usability was the biggest theme in Drupal 7. I want mobile devices to be the big thing in Drupal 8. So, this was more of a wake-up call to say, “Hey, this is what is coming up next.”

Q So, what is ‘Drupal for mobile’ going to be like?

The most interesting thing about the mobile is that it’s many different things to many different people. For some people, it’s being able to experience a regular website on a phone. So for that, we need to do HTML5, because some of the features of HTML5 allow you to optimise that experience. It also means responsive design, like images that will scale based on the screen size. It also means you need to do device discovery. So it’s a long list of check-boxes. On the flip side, for some people the mobile means native applications that run on iOS or on Android. For those things, we need a completely different set of technologies. When I say we need to do mobile, I really mean we need to do all of that. So we are evolving the Drupal architecture and we are extending its feature sets, so that Drupal can truly become one of the *de facto* platforms for building mobile applications. It means we have to do a lot of different things.

An insight into Drupal 8

Q When are you coming up with Drupal 8?

We don’t know yet. If I were to guess, I would say a year-and-a-half to two years from now. It’s a rough guess. The reason I don’t know yet is because I want Drupal 7 to take its time. I want it to be a default release. It’s gradually getting there. I want everybody to be comfortable with Drupal 7. I want all of the Drupal talent to really truly understand Drupal 7. So, I want the entire eco-system, the entire community to fully embrace Drupal 7 before we even set a date for Drupal 8.

Q What will Drupal 8 be like?

Drupal 8 will focus on a number of things. The No. 1 thing would be the mobile, as mentioned earlier. It will also bring along configuration management, which is important for a lot of large organisations. It allows them to better manage configuration changes. Drupal 8 will have more usability improvements as it’s important for both small and large users. Some enterprise features will be added to make it attractive for large organisations, for better management of their Drupal sites.

Drupal can make big money...

Q You said Drupal can be a big business. Please elaborate on this.

Drupal started off as a project and it is evolving now to become an industry. There are hundreds of Drupal shops

all around the world. Together, it means millions of dollars. That’s what I meant when I said it can be a big business. I see it growing even more. I think it can be a multi-billion dollar industry. I would like it to grow from two per cent of the Web to hopefully ten or more per cent of the Web. For this, we need to grow the entire eco-system. Hence, trips like these will be required.

I think open source is an opportunity to disrupt a lot of software technologies, specifically those which I would describe as commodity technologies, for example, websites.

Q What is the business model of Acquia?

When I started Acquia, the initial thought was to make the company supportive to Drupal as Red Hat is for Linux. We started off with the Acquia Network, just like the Red Hat Network or the JBoss network. The Acquia Network gives you commercial support with service level agreements as well as access to a number of electronic services like performance monitoring—exactly the way the Red Hat model works.

However, we quickly discovered that there are additional products that we wanted to build. So, today we have three products. Acquia Network remains the main source of revenue. The second is Acquia Cloud, a scalable hosting solution. We are able to dynamically scale Drupal websites across many servers. In addition to the elasticity, we have also developed a lot of tools that help you manage Drupal websites; so you get source-code-management tools, and you get development staging and production environments. So it’s a complete solution to help you manage Drupal sites, from hosting to development tools, to support. And then we have Drupal Gardens, software as a service, which is a fully hosted solution. It is targeted at enterprises that want to build micro-sites, and small and medium enterprise businesses. So these are the three products. And then we have a consulting practice as well, where we do architecture advice, security audits, performance scalability audits and training. Training is a big issue, particularly in India, where we have found a lot of interest from the community.

Q All these deployments in India or in the US are through partners, or does Acquia do them itself?

We, as a company, don’t build websites ourselves. We always work with partners. Sometimes the partners come to us with a lead, like, “Here is a customer and we would like you to be involved in providing some expert services.” Sometimes, customers come to us, and we go and find the partners, depending upon the need. We basically do the match-making in these cases. For some of the customers, the location of the